



A LEAKAGE IN A PIPELINE IS FIXED AFTER A THEFT

Pipeline PLUNDER

The pilferage of crude oil grows into a flood in Gujarat with the connivance of top police officials

| By Uday Mahurkar |

In the dark of the night, an oil tanker pulls up near a one-room structure at a farm in the Sarkhej area near Ahmedabad. Two men jump out of the vehicle, grab the end of a pipe jutting out of the room and lower it into the tanker. In the room, two others, including one Indravadan Patel alias Bodio, open a tap and crude oil gushes through the pipe into the

10,000-litre tanker. In a few minutes the tanker is full and it heads towards a furnace dealer at Maninagar in Ahmedabad where he is waiting to empty it into his storage tanks. The exercise is repeated twice by the four-member gang that sells the crude oil to the furnace dealer at Rs 10 a litre, raking in Rs 30 lakh for a night's work. The furnace dealer on the other hand makes Rs 10 on every litre of crude oil that works as the furnace oil as well used in industrial units.

This is Operation Oil Theft, Bodio style. Bodio, 52, and his gang of three robbed oil worth nearly Rs 200 crore over nine months from this single hole they made in a ONGC (Oil and Natural Gas Corporation) pipeline before they were caught. The Bodio gang alone made over Rs 80 crore, allegedly paying Rs 75 lakh as monthly bribe to senior police officers in Ahmedabad, including two inspector generals and two superintendents. The buyers of Bodio's stolen oil are